

ASSABIAN RITES

By Jonathan Drake

The Arts of Persuasion

Adapted from Age of Treason: The Iron Simulacrum

Design Notes

This article attempts to adapt for Mythras a chapter I originally wrote for a Legend book (*Age of Treason: The Iron Simulacrum*) covering the use of persuasion skills. That book is no longer generally available, so perhaps a conversion to Mythras, which carries a lot of Legend's core design DNA, might be a useful tool for Mythras GMs and players. Some additional guidance and thoughts about the use of social skills, adjudicating social conflict and social 'combat' have been added. These rules don't align with the more recent take on Social Conflict presented in the *Mythras Companion*, which closely parallels the Mythras combat system with Initiative, Actions, Damage Dice, quasi Hit Points and Locations (Resolution Pools) and even Special Effects. But the objective is much the same – to provide more tools to design and resolve social conflict encounters or 'scenes' and heighten narrative tension and drama. If you do have the Companion, the section on Framing the Conflict (pp17-18) is good advice whichever resolution mechanics you choose. My approach for the Thennla setting in Legend, revisited here for Mythras, sweats the core

skills and game system mechanics to achieve that objective rather than devising a new subsystem. There's no assumption here that *conflict* is involved at all. It may be the 'target' on which a character is using her skills is susceptible or amenable to the attempt, or at least has no strong reason to be opposed and to muster their Willpower against it. But some detailed guidelines are provided about when difficulty grades should be applied. The *Attitudes* table provides a way of attributing the degree of challenge inherent in a persuasion test. And the Task Round system found in the Core Rulebook (CRB) under Equipment Manufacturing and Quality is here pressed into service to handle more long drawn-out challenges.

Social skills are there to anchor the resolution of interaction with NPCs in game mechanics rather than freeform roleplaying. Some people find acting out social interaction much easier and enjoyable than others do. But making good use of the excellent Mythras rules helps level the playing field for those who enjoy problem-solving but don't want the outcome to be solely dictated by the skill and enthusiasm with which they act out their parts. After all the

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character's social skills are what are being tested, not the player's. It doesn't matter how persuasive a speaker you are, the GM should ultimately listen to you say your piece and then ask for a skill roll to see how well your player character delivers it.

The rules here provide a framework to encourage players to plan their strategy for some social encounters no less than they would for a key combat challenge. This speaks to preparing the ground, finding out more about your target and what motivates them, anticipating potential obstacles, thinking of ways to get around them and how to build the chances the dice will fall in your favour

Social conflict can be a team effort, as different members of a party take on different roles, from spokesperson, to researcher, to back-channels diplomat, agent provocateur, seducer, or simply lending reputation and status to a cause. These guidelines provide a range of ways in which social interaction and social conflict can be just as much an opportunity for a party of adventurers to work together as combat encounters can be.

I also hope these rules encourage and reward putting character development points into 'soft' persuasion skills, and spending experience rolls or training time making them better. And also help GMs think in the round about the character, emotional state, passions and prejudices of their NPCs which can bring life to an encounter, but can also be rewarding as the key motivations behind the plot of a scenario.

Persuasion and Influence

So what exactly are we talking about? For the purposes of this article, the art of persuasion involves any situation in which:

- the skills of one character are used to directly affect a decision or choice made by another by persuading them to a specific course of action, or



- a character uses their skills to indirectly affect the future behaviour, decisions or choices made by another by influencing the opinions and emotional state on which they base them.

The first of these is treats an Influence roll the same as any other skill-based challenge. You state your case, make your roll. Maybe the roll is opposed. If the dice fall in your favour then you get the result you were looking for. But the second takes a little more thinking about. It's probabilistic rather than deterministic, because you are using your powers of influence and persuasion to increase the likelihood someone will act the way you want them to.

An attempt at persuasion may be a one-on-one action, for example trying to talk an official into turning a blind eye to a minor misdemeanour, or attempting to seduce someone into sharing trust and possible intimacy with you. But it can be one person who attempts to influence many, such as an orator in front of a crowd encouraging them to march on the town hall, a captain addressing troops to persuade them to stand firm when the monsters come. It can be adversarial, for example when two lawyers compete to make their case in front of a judge or jury. And it can be a campaign of persuasion, intimidation or seduction involving multiple encounters and several characters each doing their bit.

There is no reason why Player Characters as well as Non-Player-Characters cannot be subject to persuasion attempts and be required to act accordingly – so long as a gaming group is comfortable with roleplaying the consequences, for example creating a new Passion or modifying a Passion's value.

Summary

First, frame the situation and objectives, considering the opportunities for different player characters to undertake specific roles or actions, either before, during or in-between attempts to persuade an opponent. This is especially relevant if using Task Rounds (see below) to undertake the influence attempt over hours, days, weeks or longer, rather than a single roll.

Second, consider the Attitude of non-player characters, which modifies relevant skill rolls depending upon the situation and objectives. Consider how the Sympathies, Prejudices or Mood of key non-player characters can be discovered and influenced by player characters, shifting Attitudes to support their influence attempt. If there are additional social, class, cultural or language barriers to navigate, how might these be tackled or what modifiers might apply? And finally, if 'honest persuasion' looks a little chancy, can a bit of bribery swing the balance?

Third, review the wide range of social skills that may be used, and note the circumstances that may make them more or less useful to the situation and objectives.

Finally the influence attempt(s) are played out (assuming a Bribe hasn't made this unnecessary!). This can be a simple skill roll, an Opposed Roll, or played out using the Task System and Task Rounds, for permanent or complex efforts at persuasion.

Framing the Situation and Setting Objectives

A persuasion attempt may have an immediate pay-off, for example getting someone to agree to let you in to a restricted area or persuading a henchman to stand their ground instead of running away. The GMs job is to make a fair assessment of whether a roll is needed, if so at what grade of difficulty. And whether or not the roll should be contested, perhaps matching a character's Influence skill against the target's Willpower.

Persuasion can also be the key element in a scenario or session of play and this needs framing in a more involved way to feel like a challenge or achievement. Some examples:

- Agreeing a peace deal between rival city states, cults or crime gangs;
- Securing a deal to run trade through a barbarian tribe's territory;
- Seducing someone of high status or influence when there are rivals willing to do anything to stop you succeeding;
- Stirring up a rebellion;
- Winning a high-stakes court case;
- Persuading a powerful supernatural entity to provide you with magical support

These are all meaty opportunities for play if they are used to provide multiple challenges which can engage more than one PC in planning, action and skill rolls as they are complex enough to be team efforts. Applying to be a member of a Brotherhood or Order, perhaps normally handled in downtime could take a similar path. For example to get a place at the state-sponsored Sorcery school at Felsang in Tarsenia might require Bureaucracy augmented by Influence to get on the shortlist; Literacy to pass a basic aptitude test; and a final Influence to convince the examiner.

When using the Task Rounds (see below) it is quite possible for each round to make use of a

different skill, for example: Influence to secure access for the initial conversation; Dance to impress at the Ball; Courtesy to assure the target's nearest and dearest that you are the right kind of person to be in their close company; and Seduction to close the deal.

Attitudes

When framing social interaction, a key thing for the GM to think about is the Attitude of those involved. Attitudes stand alongside Passions as a handy way to think about the emotional state of the targets and how that will affect the outcomes of social interaction. An Attitude can be something a character has had drilled into them in their upbringing, but it can also be a transitory thing resulting from recent experience, trauma or a joy. Attitude can help or hinder a situation, so essentially sets the difficulty of a task. For example if an adventurer is trying to provoke someone into a fight, a target in a *cheerful* mood is unlikely to play along so the task is hard, whereas if they are already in an *angry* mood they could be much easier to goad.

Someone with good social skills can use them to change or negate the target's Attitude. Comforting a victim of crime, stiffening a

soldier's morale, calming the anger of a furious mob.

We can break these down into three areas: Mood, Sympathies and Resolve. Individuals can have Attitudes, but so can groups of people like army units, theatre audiences and angry pitchfork-wielding peasant mobs. We also need to take into account any Passions that are relevant to the situation.

MOOD indicates the target's emotional state, which affects the type of action they will be willing to engage in, and potentially their willingness to talk. Mood is the most fickle and changeable of the Attitudes, and can change even within the course of a single encounter. Efforts to change mood depend heavily on the social situation, and what the player-characters know, or have been able to find out, about their target. The player should decide how their character is going to attempt to shift a target's mood, for example the action could involve offering exotic gifts, a performance via suitable Dance, Sing or Musicianship skills, or just flattery using Oratory or Deceit.

Mood often applies to reactions where more trivial matters are concerned. Even so, what is trivial for a king could be life-changing (or life-threatening) for their subjects.

Folk Magic: The Calm spell will move the target's *mood* one step closer towards Indifferent. A suitable spell producing the opposite effect should be allowed.

RESOLVE indicates how motivated a character or group of people are to stick to their purpose. For example it may represent how confident someone is about their opinions on issue they are being pressed on, or It can represent the morale of an individual or group of people. Where Willpower is used to resist a persuasion attempt, it can be modified by Resolve. Where there is no resistance roll, Resolve may affect the difficulty of the roll. Changing a target's resolve may be an inspiring speech of encouragement or weasel words that minimise the apparent downside of taking a less resolute



Attitude Table					
Random (D20)	Mood	Resolve	Sympathies	Passions	Difficulty Modifier
01	Violent	Shaken	Implacable	91%+	+/- 3 Grades
02-03	Angry	Wavering	Hostile	76-90%	+/- 2 Grades
04-06	Sullen	Uncertain	Prejudiced	50-75%	+/- 1 Grade
07-14	Indifferent	Indifferent	Indifferent	01-49%	None
15-17	Happy	Confident	Supportive	50-75%	+/- 1 Grade
18-19	Cheerful	Indomitable	Partisan	76-90%	+/- 2 Grades
20	Ecstatic	Fanatical	Fervent	91%+	+/- 3 Grades

approach. Outside of choosing the right words it could involve revealing an uncomfortable truth, for example showing a magistrate hard evidence that his superiors are corrupt. Or it could involve intimidation, such as making dark threats about the future safety of the target's loved ones, or even a dramatic gesture, tossing a sack of heads taken from previous opponents at the feet of the persuasion target!

Folk Magic: as an alternative mechanism Demoralise or Fanaticism spells can drive an Indifferent target's Resolve two steps towards the relevant extreme instead of inducing a temporary Passion.

SYMPATHIES indicates whether a target has existing opinions and prejudices that affect how receptive they are to what someone else has to say. Sympathies (which when negative include prejudices) often derive from deeply ingrained world view and take time or a dramatic moment that forces a rethink of that world view to change. The GM should decide if Sympathies are a factor in any situation. They should always reflect the way the target thinks about a person, whether this is the accused in murder trial, the lawyer or advocate, or even the witness. Sympathies are something people can choose to have or to set aside, or to be aware of and consciously attempt to rise above. They are more malleable than Passions, and it is a reasonable objective to shift, deflect or redirect a target's Sympathies. Detecting a target's Sympathies may be a use for Insight, or perhaps simply a Customs or Culture roll. Winning hearts and minds or stirring them up can be a job for Influence, Deceit or Oratory, but a shared Passion could also be called upon

and depending on what the proposed object of Sympathies are then Seduction may prove the ideal skill to use.

Folk Magic: Glamour can be used to ensure a character experiences more positive Sympathies from those they encounter. A suitable spell producing the opposite effect should be allowed.

PASSIONS can affect persuasion attempts in either direction. It is easier to provoke someone to fight for the liege lord towards whom they have a Loyalty passion or to defend the family they love, than it is to challenge that loyalty or to persuade them to abandon those they love. Modifiers should apply if the persuasion attempt conflicts with or takes advantage of a Passion held by the target, through the rules for Augmenting skill rolls.

Passions may serve as a modifier to the target's skill in an Opposed contest, or Passion may be used as an opposing roll rather than as a passive modifier.

Attempts to alter or suppress a target's Passion will have an effect lasting CHA hours. Passions are an ingrained, deep-seated emotional phenomenon. A target's Passions can be affected using the Seduction skill.

CHANGING ATTITUDES

Usually a successful skill roll appropriately deployed will move a target's Attitude one step in a direction desired by the character, and a Critical roll will result in a two step change. A failure has no effect and a fumble can result in

a two step change in the opposite direction to that desired.

A target character whose Attitude is affected in a way that sends them 'off the scale' will turn their Attitude into an appropriate course of action immediately. For example a *Wavering* soldier whose Resolve is affected by two steps will at once take to their heels. A *Fanatical* one who is further fired up becomes immediately impetuous and will launch a potentially suicidal attack.

The duration of a change of Attitude can vary a great deal with the circumstances, however as a rule of thumb a change in MOOD lasts for the duration of the situation or scene (equivalent to Folk Magic). A change in RESOLVE lasts for hours or days, while a change in SYMPATHIES can last for years or even for a lifetime.

Persuasion Skills

Mythras provides the Standard skill of Influence and the Professional skills of Oratory and Seduction. One of these – Seduction – is here given a wider range of applications than provided in the CRB. And as described in Mythras and expanded upon here, successful rolls in many other skills can be deployed to increase the chance of success. GM and players are encouraged to look at how other character actions and skills used to gain intelligence, deceive, impress, charm and intimidate, will affect the chances of success and failure.

With team play it is possible to allocate roles and tasks to soften up the target by fair means or foul, remove obstacles to success, or perhaps step in to speak on a friend's behalf at the right moment.

ACTING

Acting is pretending to be someone (or something) you are not. It's much more than disguise – a successful use of Acting should elicit emotional reactions from those who watch and observe the actor in their role. The audience reacts to their adopted persona

rather than their true self. Where Sympathies are concerned, people will now react to the actor in accordance with how they feel about the role she is playing, not her true self. It can be used to blend in or to stand out, to deflect the attentions of others (whether friendly or hostile) or invite them.

An Acting roll may be effective in eliciting emotional responses from an audience, and a successful roll can shift the audience mood by one grade in the direction desired by the actor, or two in the case of a Critical roll.

A successful Acting roll can also prepare the ground for a deception, meaning that a subsequent attempt at Deceit will be unopposed.

COURTESY

Where this skill is available it can be used to fit in to the manners and expectations of a certain social class. A successful roll can prevent a difficult grade being applied to the use of a social skill for not being 'one of us', and a critical roll can even make skill rolls for subsequent interactions a grade easier. Courtesy can only work in this way if the character is operating within a shared culture. The skill doesn't get much use in the Thennla setting but it can be usefully pressed into service. In Korantia for example there are networks of aristocrats across city-state state lines, that indulge in connecting through social gatherings, sporting events and marriage arrangements. Like many such networks they use manners both as a common language and as a barrier to entry. Successfully breaking into these circles might require Courtesy skill.

DANCE

In the right circumstances and where it plays a prominent cultural role, similar results can be achieved using the Dance skill as with Acting, but it's usually rather more limited in its possible applications. However Dance can be used to act either on a dance partner or on an audience, depending on the context.

DECEIT

This skill can be used to oppose Insight rolls. Something player characters may find useful. After all, there will be times when the target of their persuasion attempts will be trying to find out whether or not they are genuine. Deceit is always opposed unless bribery or some other means assures the target is more than willing to believe the lies they are being told.

INFLUENCE

This is the core skill of persuasion, a Standard Skill that everyone can try. A character in a situation that calls upon a professional skill such as Seduction or Oratory can attempt to achieve their objective using Influence but with limitations on how they go about it. For example the GM could rule that if attempting to address a group of people using Influence instead of Oratory there is a difficulty grade applied if the number of people exceeds their CHA, and another if the crowd is of greater size again.

Other uses of Influence where a Professional Skill would be more appropriate could involve a contested roll, or an extended task where otherwise a single roll would apply.



INSIGHT

This Standard Skill is perhaps the most important in the art of persuasion. An Insight role should result in information from the GM

that helps a character choose the right strategy and weigh up their chances of success. It may reveal something about the target's Attitudes, provide a big clue about what buttons to press, negating a potential penalty or providing an advantage, or simply allowing them to set an achievable objective for their persuasion attempt (see below).

Insight isn't a magical innate ability. To get the chance for an Insight role, a character must have the chance to read a room, observe behaviour in a group, or question an individual to get some measure of their character, in which case it may be opposed by the target's Deceit skill, should they deliberately be trying to hide their feelings or opinions.

ORATORY

A successful Oratory roll steers the Attitudes of an audience to a purpose. For example an orator who brings a crowd onside during an election can use the Mood, Resolve or Sympathies of the crowd to affect the outcome of the subsequent vote by raising or lowering those emotions, or perhaps ensuring they are attached to a specific person, party or issue.

The Voice Folk Magic Spell can be used to make sure you get everyone's attention, or perhaps to negate a difficulty grade caused by confusion and commotion, background noise or rival voices.

Oratory takes time to deliver, requiring a minimum of 30-CHA minutes attention from the audience. An audience can be any group of three or more people, but despite the feedback loop of cheers, applause, heckling and booing, oratory is not a conversation. The audience must be prepared to listen to the orator. Oratory can take three forms according to its purpose:

- **Rabble Rousing (Mood)** is used to whip up or calm down a mob of people, manipulating their Mood. The orator must have an issue, person, product or situation about which he

intends to make the crowd feel happy or angry. If a mob turns violent it must be given a target for their violence or will turn on whatever is conveniently close to hand – smashing up and looting local shops, picking on outsiders or anyone else they imagine a reason to dislike and beating them up or worse. So long as the shift in mood is not the result of a fumble, the orator can control such a mob for a number of minutes equal to his charisma, after which they will start to lose direction and find their own.

- **Harangue (Resolve)** is a short and simple speech designed to encourage or admonish a crowd of followers. Raising or lowering their Resolve. Very much a required performance for generals about to lead their men into battle, or for a priestess who wants to instil the fear of the gods in her flock. The effect of a Harangue lasts for a number of hours equal to the Orator's CHA.
- **Rhetoric (Sympathies)** is deployed at court, in political assemblies and in the courtroom to make a case as part of a formal procedure for deliberation and decision. A successful Oratory roll shifts the listeners' Sympathies in respect of the subject of the speech in the direction desired by the orator. The use of Rhetoric can be supported by application of the Forensics skill (see Shores of Korantia).

SEDUCTION

Seducing someone doesn't need to be about provoking sexual or erotic desire or romantic love. A successful Seduction attempt can simply mean that the target takes the seducer into their heart – and into their confidence. Seduction offers promises of desires and ambitions fulfilled, perhaps a touch of glamour and excitement, or simply plays to the personal insecurities or vanities of the target.



A successful Seduction roll may mean being treated like family when you have no blood relation, becoming a trusted member at the heart of a crime gang, or securing the influential spot behind the throne from where private counsel can be whispered into the ruler's ear. It can also be used to entice or recruit someone into an intimate circle such as a cult or brotherhood where confidences, secrets and trusts are held close.

Seduction can sometimes take place over the course of a single encounter, but needs hours rather than minutes to work, access to get inside the personal space of the target, and the results are temporary, typically lasting for the seducer's CHA in hours.

But Seduction can also take place over multiple Task Rounds with the intention of instilling a Passion in the target – usually Love or Loyalty – at its base level, or removing completely one they already have. The GM and player should agree duration of these Task Rounds, but each should be a separate encounter between the



seducer and target. As usual, a final total of 100% or greater is required to achieve the desired effect.

SING

Along with Musicianship, Sing can be used to perform to work on an audience's Mood to much the same end as Acting or Dance. It can be a step on the road to seduction, and with the right choice of song it could be used to raise or lower the Mood of an audience, or even raise Resolve by getting a crowd, or a band of soldiers, to join in a war song or anthem with gusto.

OPPOSED ROLLS

If in doubt over a straight roll or an opposed roll contest, consider whether the target is *actively* disagreeing or not. If it's a simple case of making an argument and the target taking in what the character has to say and deciding whether to go along with it or not, there's no reason to assume the roll should be opposed. Many times the target simply won't have thought about what they are being asked to believe or to agree with before, and if there is no obvious bad outcome for them they don't have a resistance that needs to be overcome. In this case a simple unopposed roll is enough, perhaps modified for difficulty using Attitudes and other factors. However a debate in which two characters actively promote opposing

ideas calls for Opposed Rolls. And in any situation in which a character is using Deceit, then the target should have the opportunity of a passive opposing roll to see through the deception, perhaps using Insight.

TASK ROUNDS

An attempt to influence a target's Attitudes is usually a single skill roll, although the effect may be temporary. But to permanently affect change, to engender a Passion in the target, or to get a target to make a complex decision to the player's advantage can be a multi-stage quest, taking place in Local Time or even Strategic Time. It may, for example, take several encounters before the object of your affections agrees to go out with you on a date. It could take several dates before you get to move the relationship on to the next stage.

To represent these situations I have made use of the Task Rounds system found in the CRB under Equipment Manufacturing and Quality in the Economics and Equipment chapter. It's a system for processes where you will 'get there in the end' if you keep working at something and have the tools, time and resources available. In which if you rush things you may increase the difficulty, but taking extra time and care can bring advantages. It's a mechanic that can apply to tasks of persuasion as much as making wine or forging a weapon – except that in the case of persuasion there is usually another human being (or even supernatural entity) involved who may keep frustrating your best efforts (via Opposed Rolls or simply refusing to engage) and you may not have the opportunity to engineer sufficient encounters – or Task Rounds – to be successful. A fumble on the way probably dooms the endeavour, because the target is likely to break off all contact. But otherwise persistence may eventually pay off. It's possible the Task Round approach can be used even if each round may have a different skill that applies. If mixing things up this way there should be one key skill that has to be succeeded in at least once for any kind of success.

ENHANCEMENTS

The Item Quality rules (see CRB) could equally apply to the product of social interaction. A final results to a Task of less than 100% perhaps results in a shoddy agreement that the ruling council refuses to ratify, or that causes confusion, resentment and conflict when people try to implement it or a relationship that doesn't last or is ill-fated. Results greater than 100% allow Enhancements to be applied: use the Enhancements Table as a guide. No persuasion outcome come benefit from more than two Enhancements of the same type

Bribery

Influence rolls can often be augmented by a bribe. Even where corruption is frowned on there is always the chance you will find an individual prepared to look the other way or agree to something they otherwise wouldn't for financial gain. Bribery can be part of an Influence, Commerce or Oratory roll, and in certain circumstances can be used with a Deceit or Seduction roll.

Offering the right bribe can do one of the following, and the player whose character is attempting the bribe must choose what the intended effect of the bribe is before making the Influence roll:

- It can remove any opposed roll to the Influence attempt

- It can short-cut what might otherwise be an extended task: rather than gently persuading or subverting the target over time, a single opposed roll is made
- It can make the roll one grade easier

These effects are stackable, but each additional advantage being sought doubles the cost.

A failed Influence roll supported by a bribe has no effect – the bribe is declined and the character keeps his money. The roll can be retried if time and circumstances permit and the initial bribe is at least doubled.

With a critical success the target not only accepts the bribe and does what is asked, but will provide additional help and make very clear they are open for further business in the future – perhaps even an ongoing retainer. Rarely the target may do what is asked but have an attack of conscience and decline the money.

A fumble results in the target swiping the money and not even trying to deliver; or perhaps refusing the bribe and calling out the attempted dishonesty for all to hear, or reporting the attempt to their superiors. Perhaps they are merely insulted by the clumsy, low-ball offer. Such things can end badly, even in bloodshed.

Enhancements Table	
Enhancement	Effect
Affecting	The target's Attitude moves one step in the direction desired by the player
Inspiring	A relevant Passion is permanently increased by 1d6+6
Enduring	The duration of the effect of the persuasion skill is increased by one step: minutes become hours, hours becomes days etc
Productive	The value to be gained from a transaction or encounter is increased by 50%, or its cost is halved
Disheartening	A relevant Passion is permanently decreased by 1d6+6

Bribery Table		
<i>Bribery Objective</i>	<i>Typical Difficulty Grade</i>	<i>Base Cost of Bribe (Silver Dinars)</i>
Getting past a doorman and into an exclusive establishment	Standard	1
Getting an official or guard to look the other way when a minor crime or fraud is in process	Standard	5
Getting an official to effect a meeting or audience with an important person	Standard	15
Persuading an official to lose, alter or create an official document	Hard	50
Influencing a judge in a court case	Hard	100
Corrupting a judge to avoid conviction on a serious charge for which exile or execution is the penalty	Formidable	1,000
Securing the desertion of a mercenary captain with his 100 men	Formidable	4,000

The Bribery table provides a few examples of suitable bribes for a variety of situations. Depending on the situation and the skills of the character a Commerce, Culture, Custom, Insight, Streetwise or in some cases even Courtesy roll may provide a guide to what the right size bribe should be. In practice

the cost of a bribe is dependent on the status of the person you are trying to bribe, how much they need the money, the likelihood of them getting found out, the consequences to themselves if they are – and of course the trouble they have to go to.

Corruption runs deep in many societies, and a bribe can be a requirement to doing business. In places such as Djemirket bribery can be an accepted part of life, priced in to everyday transactions, in which case the only likely opposing roll is Commerce.

Some jobs are very poorly paid – or not at all – because they bring with them the chance to make money in bribes. Even so, failure to offer a bribe of sufficient value is taken as an insult. Custom and Culture are useful skills in finding out whether a bribe is likely to be culturally acceptable.

In the Taskan Empire offering a bribe to a state official amounts to treason, and the roll is always opposed by the target's Willpower, or their Loyalty (Emperor) whichever is higher,

and the bribe cannot be used to negate the opposing roll.

Of course some individuals are easier to turn than others. If the target can be engaged in conversation or observed over time an Insight roll will give clues as to whether personal principles, weaknesses or even financial hardship may make them more or less susceptible than others in similar positions.

Handling Social and Cultural Barriers

As a GM it's easy to overplay social divisions. The advice here is to think about many different aspects and angles of social interaction and mine it for material to play with, rather than rubbing players' noses in the social divisions that affect their characters' lives. Hard social divides – between lord and commoner, free and slave, between castes, age classes or perhaps between genders can present any number of challenges to be overcome especially when these differences are institutionalised or systemic. But in the end always remember people are people. They can relate to one another as human beings, not only as cyphers.

On a practical level different cultures have different mannerisms as well as a host of other signals in speech and action that can be hard to read and even unfathomable for others.

BRIBERY EXAMPLE

Inquisitor Darush is pressuring Zarinian crime boss Varshang Keban to reveal what he knows about an illicit trade in magical texts conducted by dishonest scholars at the Great Library. The GM informs Darush's player that persuading this leading light of the city's underworld to inform on a major criminal operation is going to require an extended task. Darush knows it is against Varshang's principles to talk. The GM interprets this as having an Indomitable resolve (so imposing a two grade skill penalty, to Formidable difficulty). But Darush knows it's equally against his principles to refuse a large amount of money, so a bribe is likely to be very helpful.

Darush calculates (Streetwise) that 1,000 Taskeens may have an effect, however he doesn't want to risk a refusal and gets authorisation from his superiors to go up to 4,000 Taskeens. By doubling the size of the bribe twice he can select two additional bribery effects. His player decides on an instant skill test with no opposed roll and to reduce the difficulty grade from Formidable to Hard, so his 60% skill is now at 40%. With a roll of 37, Darush succeeds in getting the information in time to catch the spell-smuualers red-handed.

Something as simple as a smile can have different subtexts and meaning from one culture to another. The GM should apply a difficulty modifier of one or more grades to Insight rolls and/or to persuasion rolls where the people involved are from cultures that are very different. One way to address these challenges is that having any score in the relevant Culture skill negates a level of difficulty, and a successful roll for the skill can negate a second, if required.

There's nothing said here about racial divisions. In the ancient-world inspired

Thennla setting *cultural* prejudice and antipathy abounds. But race in terms of skin colour or physiognomy is pretty much irrelevant to the world's inhabitants. This is even true when considering the tribes of the far West and South: the Orcs; the Tribes of Jandekot, who can be oversized, undersized, scarlet or blue-skinned, hairless and even 4-breasted; and the Uxmali, who come in two distinct strains one of which feeds on the other. No matter how 'different' they are physiologically and even psychologically, they remain 'human'. There are no 'non-human' races, and this is a deliberate design choice of the setting to step away from the clichés of fantasy races in RPG settings and literature. On the other hand characters who do bump into elves or goblins in the setting will soon discover they are magical-supernatural beings rather than humanoid races.

SOCIAL STATUS

In the Legend book *Age of Treason*, Social Status was an additional Characteristic rolled on 3d6 that was used to calculate certain skills



and attributes. Mythras has a straightforward percentage roll to determine a character's social status at creation stage, but it isn't very much referenced from that point on within the rules system and of course it's potentially a very setting-specific question. It's suggested here that the GM should take note of the relative social status of influencer and target, and if there is a significant gulf between them that's relevant to the situation, apply modifiers to skill rolls accordingly.

How you handle it is a question of what kind of game and what kind of setting you like to work with, but these status barriers are very much part of most historical cultures even if they are very differently drawn. As Thennla takes its inspiration for the way people and cultures behave from real world history it works well as a setting in which to think about social barriers.

It is also worth considering status within and between the cults and brotherhoods that are present in your setting. Some will have egalitarian ideals where all ranks are encouraged to speak freely, others revel in enforcing a strict hierarchy and rule and create a mystique around senior ranks. For example the beggars of Sorandib may all just be beggars to everyone else, but among themselves they have a very rigid hierarchy. Some of these organisational cultures may be felt just as strongly as the social divisions within the wider community, and in some settings social class and rank within Cults and Brotherhoods as described in the CRB are one and the same.

LANGUAGE BARRIERS

Verbal communication is a key part of persuasion and so not being able to fluently communicate in the language of your target is a serious problem. But it's not totally insurmountable. As persuasion is a two-way process, the GM should use the lower of the influencer or the target's Language skill as a cap on the Persuasion skill being used. Exceptions can be made for interactions where the GM can judge that the verbal part of the communication is of limited relevance.



If reduced to non-verbal communication because influencer and target have no language in common it is still possible to get a message across with patience and persistence. The attempt can be handled using Task Rounds, and depending on the message that's being attempted a task round could be measured in combat rounds of frantic gesturing or days of careful attempts to achieve mutual understanding.

The Language Barrier may mean it's better for the PC with the best language skill rather than the one with the best persuasion skill to lead the effort. But it may still be possible for another character who doesn't have the language to augment the roll by providing advice along the way.

CLASS BARRIERS

People of a more elevated social class may write you off as a dull-witted country bumpkin because you come from the wrong family, the wrong village, or even the wrong city. They may like you well enough but know that associating with you, or giving you a break, brings no social benefits and you are certainly not the calibre of person to consider marriage to. In some situations this will result in difficulty grades being applied to skill rolls when you are dealing with them.

People of humbler backgrounds may have a culturally ingrained sense of respect for hierarchy, and attribute their social superiors with greater intelligence and authority than they really have, be wowed by the glamour of wealth and position, and this can bring easier skill roll grades to interactions for a character of higher social status.

For example if you are trying to secure a bride of a different social rank than your own, for every step by which the suitor and target differ in Social Class, the task is one grade easier or more difficult.

Conversely people can show inverse snobbery: perhaps a deep-seated distrust and dismissal of the wealthy, aristocrats, celebrities, politicians, intellectuals and others they consider social parasites, show-offs, toffs and chinless wonders. Unless you are dealing with a culture or social group where these attitudes are commonplace or have been mobilised by crafty politicians and orators, inverse snobbery tends to be an individual character trait.

Whenever a character is in a situation where their social class might be a problem, a successful Acting roll can hide it, a Courtesy roll may help use the right tone to get the ear of a 'high-up', or a Customs (perhaps even Streetwise) roll can be used to negate such a penalty for someone trying to be relatable to people below their social rank.

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